Xenophobia – A Collection

By Daryl Ngee Chinn

Skin Color From the Sun

Chinese are

--mathematical

--docile, unassertive, quiet

-- skinny, short martial artists

--good ping pong players

--poor English speakers

--studious

--nearsighted

--good cooks and laundry workers

--engineers, doctors, or optometrists

--a model minority

--not poets . . . .

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INTRODUCTION

*Chinese are more than a stereotype. Chinese have been and **are** . . . an integral part of American society . . .*

And then 2020 arrived with the first reported case of COVID-19 in Wuhan, China. Since the beginning of the pandemic, President Trump and other officials have kindled flames of anti-Asian sentiment by referring to COVID-19 as the "China Virus" and even the "kung flu." Doing so has helped normalize anti-Asian xenophobia.

But unfortunately, this is nothing new. The racist belief that Asians carry disease goes back centuries. In the 1800s, out of fear that Chinese workers were taking jobs that could be held by white workers, white labor unions argued for an immigration ban by claiming that "Chinese" disease strains were more harmful than those carried by white people.

Skin Color from the Sun and Not Translation, Not Poetry by Daryl Ngee Chinn

Not Translation, Not Poetry

Ask the old men in Chinatown,

the ones who washed and ironed in laundries

cooked in restaurants, fished in San Francisco Bay,

laid rocks and track from California to Utah

and then down to Los Angeles.

These old men remember

that the rocks and snow in the Sierras
are softer and warmer than memories
of interrogators and officials on Angel Island
who said, "It is my duty to question your past,
to find out if you know where the stove was
back in your home in China. And it is my judgment
that this man who calls himself your brother
and these women who claim to be your wife and mother
are liars and will be sent back to China."

These men never had a wife to rub their tired shoulders
or to warm their bed. They never had children
climbing their laps or searching their pockets
for quarters or candy.
They never heard their mothers complaining
or saw them washing vegetables.
Even if they had owned all the tea in China,
they never drank tea with their brothers again.

That short chapter
in the middle of a book
about Chinese-American dreams fulfilled

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has no darkness for your dreaming,
no scenery, demons, romance, epic<
only a spotlight on
laws, numbers, facts, dates,
history you and I
should have learned in the eleventh grade.

Go back and ask your teachers
about the California Congressman who used eloquence
and power in 1882 to argue and lobby for
the exclusion, from the pursuit of happiness in America,
of all Chinese laborers
    --would-be laundrymen, houseboys,
    fishermen, farmers, cigarmakers, gravediggers –
and about the Congressman who wrote the law
that kept all Chinese women
from entering the United States
from 1902 to 1946. Wasn't that when
your grandparents came to America?

Ask the white women who never asked their husbands
why they killed Chinese

in Utah, after they finished the railroad in 1865,
in Los Angeles in 1871,
in Rock Springs, Wyoming, in 1885.
Ask the kids who ran to the docks in 1886
to watch their fathers put pigtailed men
on steamboats in Humboldt Bay.

Ask Judge Kaufman of Detroit
who said in 1982
that Robert Ebens and Michael Nitz,
who killed Vincent Chin with a Louisville Slugger,
could have probation and a suspended fin
because Vincent Chin looked Japanese.

Pretend you are Caucasian and pregnant
like Christina Tien of Grand Ledge, Michigan>
It is New Year's Day, 1985.
Imagine how much warmth and softness
you feel when four men with knives
Slash your car tires outside in the snow,
break your living room windows with crowbars

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and say, "We want to speak with your husband
and any other Chinks in the house."

You don't understand my anger

TRANSITION

But we should try. Our poet, Daryl Ngee Chinn, has personally faced systemic racism throughout his career. But so too have Blacks, Latinos, and Jews. Is America truly a 'melting pot' or is America a simmering stew of unrest? Is multi-culturalism a reality or merely a pipe dream?

Skin Color From the Sun

I used to be
an admissions counselor
at Humboldt State University.

One day Penny, our secretary, told me to
pick up Line One.
I talked to this man from Palo Alto
about life in the dorms,
the low cost of movies and rent,
whether his daughter would need a car,

the friendly people,
the small classes of ten or fifteen.

When we were done, he thanked me
and asked my name. Daryl Chinn, I said.
Oh, he said, you speak very good English.
Where are you from?

I grew up in Richmond and El Cerrito, California, just
across the bay and north of where you're
calling from, I said.
Well, he said, where were you born?
Salt Lake City, I said.
Well then, where were your parents from?

My mothers' from Austin, Texas, but
her brothers and sisters were born
in Washington, D.C., and Utah and –

--no, he interrupted, where
were your ancestors from?
Using the California English I had learned
from my mother and father,

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from my teachers at Pullman Elementary,
Granada Junior High, and Harry Ells High,
I said, My father is from Southern China,
my voice flat and dead.
I wanted to ask him,
Where did you learn to speak English so well?
Where are you from, really
from?

*****

My wife and I spent a year in Florida teaching
at the University of Central Florida in Orlando.
One day, we were waiting at a stop light
near our kids' grade school. A busload
of junior high students pulled alongside.
Someone yelled out the window,
Go home Vietnamese.

******

Sticks and stones will break my bones
but names can never hurt me.

Bullshit.

*****

I, a Chink, married this Yid broad.
Our kids are half-breeds, mulattos.
We drive Frog and Nazi cars,
play a Jap stereo with good speakers
and flatlander turntable.

*****

In the high school locker room
one day just after we showered,
Lon, next to me,
said white boys smelled funny.
When I looked at him, he held his nose
and pointed silently at Jay
behind us. Later, at lunch time,
Jay said that without nigger boys
Coach wouldn't have a basketball team.

That year, just before I went to college,

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Aunt Annie said, "Just remember,
since you're Chinese, they
can't tell what you are. Black people
won't think you're white. White people
won't know if you're colored.
Both might trust you. You can be
on either side. Use your race
to be whatever you want to be."

*****

For a very long time in Europe,
Jews were forced into ghettos,
where their lives were circumscribed --
where they could live, what they could be,
who their friends could be,
where they could travel.
Some Jews found their ways out of the ghetto.
They intermarried, changed their names,
converted to Christianity,
became doctors, lawyers, royal advisors<

university scholars, and moved into
non-Jewish neighborhoods.

During the Holocaust, Adolf Hitler
convinced blond, blue-eyed women
to have babies fathered by
blond, blue-eyed men.
During the Holocaust,
if a man or woman or child
had even one grandparent who was Jewish
that person went to the ovens.

Even the children of those
blond, blue-eyed parents,
if their skin or hair or eyes
turned dark,
went to the ovens.

*****

My children come home
with questions, complaints, reports.
My son asks, Are we half-Jewish, half-Chinese?

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My daughter complains, Someone
called me a China doll.

How can we tell
what part of you is Jewish or Chinese?
I ask them. Your right eye? Your left shoulder?
Your bones? The skin below your belly button?
Tell them your ancestors came from China,
that your mother is Jewish. Tell them
you are all, both.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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